

Utilizing the CSAC Survey to Study Issues Impacting Transgender Students: A Short Research Summary

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1 Background

The California Student Aid Commission (CSAC) is the state agency that is responsible for administering financial aid programs for post-secondary education. In 2020, CSAC partnered with the California Education Lab (Ed Lab) at University of California, Davis to conduct a survey on the experiences of college students and high school seniors during the COVID pandemic. For the 2023-2024 academic year, the survey is pivoting away from COVID-19 topics and towards more general questions about the student experience with college and financial aid. This year, the survey is conducted in two waves: the first wave for graduating high school seniors, and the second wave for currently enrolled college students who file FAFSA.

As a graduate student researcher for the Ed Lab, I am on the team for the 2023 CSAC survey project and am involved in designing the surveys. The first wave for high school graduating seniors was conducted in June, and the second wave for currently enrolled college students will be conducted in September. We were able to implement detailed SOGI demographic questions (in accordance with Williams Institute guidelines) in the spring wave, in addition to some high school climate questions and questions on expectations about identity safety in college. I expect we will be continue implementing the SOGI questions in the fall wave, and I am currently considering possible questions and field experiments around discrimination against queer students as well as issues faced by them.

2 Opportunities and Challenges

The key opportunity presented by the CSAC student survey is the sheer sample size, which presents a unique opportunity to study LGBTQ+ students, who will comprise a subgroup with sufficient size given the size of the population. The survey is sent via email to all students in California who file or renew a FAFSA application for the year. There are two waves of the survey: the spring survey, which is sent to high school seniors and first-time adult college students who file their FAFSA applications; and the fall survey, which is sent to current college students who file FAFSA renewals. In addition, starting in the 2022-2023 academic year, California AB 469 requires all high school seniors to complete a FAFSA application, therefore, we expect to see an increase in the number of high school seniors who answer the survey this year.

In the 2019-2020 academic year, there were around 2.4 million FAFSA filers in California, and for the 2020 CSAC student survey, there were around 200,000 responses which gives us a response rate of 10%. Assuming 2% are transgender and 3% are non-binary ¹, this yields a sample size of 4000 transgender students and 6000 non-binary students in the sample. Additionally, assuming 6.6% are gay, lesbian, or bisexual, this would yield a sample of 13200 students ². Using statistics reported by the Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System (BRFSS) (Lee Badgett et al., 2021) as a conservative estimate and half the response rate at 5%, we still arrive at a sample of 3000 lesbian, gay, and bisexual students and a sample of 500 transgender students. This is a rare opportunity to work with a large sample of LGBTQ+ students.

The above estimation seems overly optimistic, unfortunately. In the spring survey for high school graduating seniors, we received about 8000 valid responses, a response rate of around 2.5%. This is a very low response rate compared to the 2020 wave, and we therefore need to adjust our expectations for the fall wave. In the spring wave, there were 573 students who were transgender or gender non-conforming (non-binary, genderfluid, etc., excluding those who reported unsure/questioning or prefer not to say), which is around 7% of the sample. For sexuality, around 22% of the sample reported being non-heterosexual (excluding those who reported being unsure/questioning or prefer not to state), which includes 2.5% identifying as asexual, 16% bisexual, 4.5% lesbian or gay, and 2% pansexual or queer.

¹Statistics from Pew Research Center: <https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2022/06/07/about-5-of-young-adults-in-the-u-s-say-their-gender-is-different-from-their-sex-assigned-at-birth/>

²Statistics from Gallup: <https://news.gallup.com/poll/470708/lgbt-identification-steady.aspx>

One of the key challenges for the fall survey, therefore, would be to increase response rate, and to design an experiment with sufficient power for subgroup analysis with queer students. Students did not receive any compensation for the spring survey, however, it is could be possible to implement a raffle for the fall survey. Nonetheless, due to the large sample size, we are not able to properly incentivize survey participants up to the standard of economic experiments. Another challenge is that the survey questions need to be related to student financial aid or the students' college experience. Finally, the survey length is another constraint. Since students are not receiving compensation, we need to keep the survey relatively short to reduce the possibility of respondents exiting the survey halfway (in the spring wave, around half of the respondents who started the survey did not finish it). This limits the number and types of experiments/interventions that are possible.

3 Preliminary Proposal

3.1 Attitudes towards Trans Peers and Instructors

There are two main questions I am interested in studying, and which I believe would be suitable given the context and the characteristics of the survey. The first is to investigate the discriminatory attitudes towards transgender peers and professors in college. Trans and gender nonconforming youth face a variety of challenges at school, including but not limited to access to gender-congruent bathrooms, ability to play on sports teams, bullying and harassment from peers, and discriminatory policies and actions from teachers and administrators that disrespect their gender identity and expression, and that which often leads to disciplinary actions against trans students³. According to the 2021 GLSEN National School Climate Survey, around 74% of transgender students reported feeling unsafe at school⁴. With the rapidly increasing number of anti-trans bills being introduced or passed in state legislatures across the country, the difficulties that transgender students face are likely to persist and worsen. There is also little evidence on attitudes towards transgender professors, and studying it would shed more light on the labor market experience of trans people. There has been relatively few studies documenting the discriminatory attitudes of college students towards their transgender peers, and learning more about these attitudes can reveal valuable information about the college

³National Center for Transgender Equality: <https://transequality.org/issues/youth-students>

⁴2021 GLSEN National School Climate Survey: <https://www.glsen.org/research/2021-national-school-climate-survey>

environment for policy makers. Since attitudes towards transgender people are sensitive issues, I plan to use a double list experiment to circumvent the social desirability bias problem (Glynn, 2013; Aksoy et al., 2022). The two key statements I plan to include are:

1. I would be comfortable living with a roommate who is a trans woman/man (I play to include this after the gender identity question to tailor the statement to the gender of the respondent)
2. I would be comfortable having a transgender instructor/teaching assistant

3.2 Other Questions

I described these above two questions first because I believe they are the more feasible ones, however, I have a number of other research questions that are pertinent and interesting. First, I would like to study trust and taste-based discrimination against gender and sexual minorities, using a similar design as (Fershtman and Gneezy, 2001). This would involve trust games and dictator games. Second, I am interested in the extent of inaccurate beliefs about gender and sexual minorities and how it impacts (inaccurate) statistical discrimination. This would involve the participants performing a task, as well as some variation of a hiring game and belief elicitations. Third, it would be interesting to replicate and extend (Aksoy et al., 2022) to study the self-confidence and patterns in belief updating about self evaluations among gender and sexual minorities, with finer subgroup analysis given the advantage of the larger sample. This would involve some type of real effort task that measure a proxy of ability or intelligence, as well as belief elicitations. An alternative experiment would be an intervention designed to target confidence and beliefs about self ability. One possible setup is to ask the student to report their GPA and their belief on their relative ranking and future salary range. Then we provide information on the actual ranking and salary distribution for students with similar GPAs. We can match the survey responses to administrative records and study effects on subsequent course taking, persistence in majors, and graduation.

Last but not least, I believe it would be interesting to study whether there are any differences in competitiveness and risk preferences between gender and sexual minorities and their cisgender, heterosexual peers. Again this would require real effort tasks. The main challenge common to all of the above questions is that they require proper incentives. Without the ability to provide monetary incentives, it would be difficult to ensure the validity of the experiments.

4 Conclusion

The CSAC student survey provides a unique and rare opportunity to access a large sample of sexual and gender minority students and offers great potential for conducting research on issues impacting these populations. However, the main challenges involve whether we can secure a sufficient response rate, the lack of monetary incentives, and the limitations on the length and types of questions in the survey. I have provided a brief description of some research questions that I believe are feasible and a preliminary design for them, as well as several other questions that are equally, if not more, interesting and important, but which are unfortunately less feasible given the constraints.

References

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